

Stamp Inscription Cheat-Sheet

Country and script reference

Common inscriptions, historical names and currency clues for starting an identification.

Version 2.0

Common country inscriptions

On the stamp	Likely meaning
HELVETIA	Switzerland
SUOMI	Finland
MAGYAR / MAGYARORSZÁG	Hungary
ESPAÑA	Spain
NEDERLAND	Netherlands
ÖSTERREICH	Austria
SVERIGE	Sweden
NORGE	Norway
DANMARK	Denmark
ÉIRE	Ireland
ΕΛΛΑΣ / HELLAS	Greece
POLSKA	Poland
РОССИЯ / ROSSIYA	Russia
日本 / NIPPON	Japan
BRASIL	Brazil

Historical and obsolete names

On the stamp	Likely meaning
DEUTSCHES REICH	Germany, pre-1945
CCCP / CCCP	USSR / Soviet Union
CEYLON	Sri Lanka
SIAM	Thailand
PERSIA	Iran
FORMOSA	Taiwan
BÖHMEN UND MÄHREN	Bohemia and Moravia, WWII
DANZIG	Free City of Danzig
NEDERLANDSCH-INDIË / NED. INDIË	Dutch East Indies / Indonesia
ÉTAT INDÉPENDANT DU CONGO	Congo Free State
ČESKOSLOVENSKO	Czechoslovakia
NEWFOUNDLAND	Now part of Canada
BRITISH INDIA	India under British rule

Words that are not country names

On the stamp	Likely meaning
FRIMÆRKE / POSTZEGEL / TIMBRE	stamp
POSTAGE / POSTES / CORREOS / ПОЧТА	post or postage
LÖSEN / PORTO	postage due
SERVICE / DIENST / OFFICIEL	official
FLUGPOST / LUFTPOST / AIR MAIL	airmail
MARINE-POSTKANTOOR	naval postmark, not an issuer

Currency clues

On the stamp	Likely meaning
PF / PFENNIG / MARK	Germany
CENTIME / FRANC	France, Belgium, Switzerland and colonies
КОП / КОПЕЙКА	Russia / USSR
ÖRE / KRONA	Sweden
ØRE / KRONE	Norway or Denmark
CENTESIMI / LIRE	Italy
CÉNTIMOS / PESETA	Spain
SEN / YEN	Japan
ANNA / RUPEE	British India
d / s / £	Pre-decimal UK and Commonwealth

Important clue

British stamps commonly omit the country name and show the monarch's portrait. When no name resolves, use script, portrait, currency and design together, then mark the identification low confidence until verified.